Release Readiness & Strategy

Plan how a change reaches users, check it's ready, know how to undo it, and tell the people who need to know.

Engineering Practices · Separate Deploy from Release · Go / No-Go

RELEASE _____

TARGET DATE _____

1 What's Releasing

Release / version: _____

Outcome for users: _____

Main changes: _____

Who's affected: _____

Deploy date: _____

Switch-on date: _____

2 Release Approach

TICK ONE OR COMBINE · DEPLOYING ISN'T THE SAME AS RELEASING

- ☐ **Big bang** — Everyone gets it at once. Simple, but the riskiest.
- ☐ **Feature flag** — Deploy switched off, then turn it on when ready, for some or all.
- ☐ **Canary** — A small share of users first, then more if all is well.
- ☐ **Blue-green** — Switch traffic to a new copy; switch back if it goes wrong.
- ☐ **Phased rollout** — By region, customer group or channel, one at a time.
- ☐ **Beta / early access** — Volunteers try it first and give feedback.

3 Go / No-Go Checklist

AGREE THE LIST BEFORE THE DAY

- ☐ Definition of Done met for every item
- ☐ Performance and security checks done
- ☐ Monitoring and alerts ready
- ☐ Release notes and messages ready
- ☐ Change approval recorded (if needed)
- ☐ Pipeline green, no open critical defects
- ☐ Rollback tested, not just written down
- ☐ Support and operations briefed
- ☐ Data migration rehearsed (if any)
- ☐ Someone on hand after release

Decision: ☐ Go ☐ No-go Decided by: _____ When: _____

4 Rollback & Recovery

PLAN TO UNDO IT BEFORE YOU DO IT

If it goes wrong, we'll see: _____

We'll undo it by: _____

Time to undo: _____

Who decides to roll back: _____

What we can't undo (data, messages): _____

Rollback last tested on: _____

5 Who Needs to Know

USERS, SUPPORT, SALES, OTHER TEAMS

AUDIENCE	WHAT THEY NEED TO KNOW	WHEN	HOW	OWNER

6 After Release

Check the outcome on: _____

Remove the feature flag by: _____

What we learned: _____

"If this goes wrong at the worst moment, what's our plan?"

"Could we release this a little at a time?"

© 2026 Eric Parker · CC BY 4.0 · eparker71.github.io/agile-ways-of-working